

THE LAWS OF CRICKET

Official Code & Standard Playing Conditions

MODELED AFTER THE MARYLEBONE CRICKET CLUB (MCC) CODE OF LAWS • 2026 CODE

PREAMBLE — THE SPIRIT OF CRICKET

Cricket is a game that owes much of its unique appeal to the fact that it should be played not only within its Laws but also within the **Spirit of the Game**. Any action which is seen to abuse this spirit causes injury to the game itself. The major responsibility for ensuring fair play rests with the team captains, match officials, and players alike.

LAW 1 — THE PLAYERS & CAPTAINS

- 1.1 Number of players:** A match is played between two sides, each of 11 players, one of whom shall be captain. By agreement, a match may be played with more or fewer than 11 players per side, but no more than 11 players may field at any one time.
- 1.2 Nomination of players:** Each captain shall nominate their players in writing to one of the umpires before the toss. No player may be changed after the nomination without the consent of the opposing captain.
- 1.3 Captain's responsibility:** The captains are responsible at all times for ensuring that play is conducted within the Spirit of the Game as well as within the Laws.

LAW 2 — THE UMPIRES & SCORERS

- 2.1 Appointment and control:** Two umpires shall be appointed, one for each end, to control the match with absolute impartiality. The umpires are the sole judges of fair and unfair play.
- 2.2 Sole judges of fitness of play:** The umpires shall be the final judges of the fitness of the ground, weather, and light for play.
- 2.3 Duties of scorers:** Two scorers shall be appointed to record all runs scored, wickets taken, and overs bowled as signaled by the umpires.

LAW 3 — EQUIPMENT & FIELD SPECIFICATIONS

All equipment used in official matches must comply with the standard dimensions specified below:

ITEM	STANDARD SPECIFICATIONS	KEY LIMITS / TOLERANCES
The Pitch	22 yards (20.12 m) length, 10 ft (3.05 m) width	Distance between stumps at each end
The Ball	Weight: 5.5 to 5.75 oz (155.9g – 163g)	Circumference: 8.81 to 9 in (22.4cm – 22.9cm)
The Bat	Overall length ≤ 38 in (96.5 cm)	Blade width ≤ 4.25 in (10.8 cm); depth ≤ 2.64 in
The Stumps	Height: 28 inches (71.1 cm) above surface	Overall width across 3 stumps: 9 inches (22.86 cm)
The Bails	Length: 4.31 inches (10.95 cm)	Must not extend > 0.5 in above stumps

LAW 4 — SCORING & WINNING

4.1 Runs: A run is scored when the batters, after a hit or at any time while the ball is in play, cross and reach the opposite crease.

4.2 Boundaries: A boundary four is awarded if the ball touches or crosses the boundary line after touching the ground. A boundary six is awarded if the ball clears the boundary without touching the ground.

4.3 The Result: The side which scores the greater aggregate number of runs in its completed innings shall be the winner of the match.

LAW 5 — MODES OF DISMISSAL

A batter may be dismissed in ten distinct ways during the course of play:

1. **Bowled:** The ball delivered by the bowler breaks the wicket directly or off the batter's equipment.
2. **Caught:** A legal delivery is hit by the bat/glove and caught by a fielder before touching the ground.
3. **Leg Before Wicket (LBW):** The ball hits the batter's body/pad in line without prior bat contact and would have hit the stumps.
4. **Run Out:** A fielder breaks the wicket while the batter is out of their ground while the ball is in play.
5. **Stumped:** The wicketkeeper breaks the wicket while the batter is out of their ground receiving a delivery (not attempting a run).
6. **Hit Wicket:** The batter breaks their own wicket with bat or body while attempting a shot or setting off for a run.
7. **Handled the Ball / Obstructing the Field:** A batter willfully obstructs or distracts the fielding side by word or action.
8. **Hit the Ball Twice:** The batter strikes the ball a second time with bat or body, except solely to guard their wicket.
9. **Timed Out:** An incoming batter fails to be ready to receive a shot within 3 minutes of the previous dismissal.
10. **Retired Out:** A batter leaves the field without the umpire's permission and without being injured/ill.

LAW 6 — UNFAIR PLAY & PENALTY RUNS

6.1 Illegal Bowling Actions (Chucking)

The ball must be bowled, not thrown. A throw is defined as an elbow extension exceeding 15 degrees during the delivery stride prior to the ball leaving the hand. If the umpire considers the ball thrown, they shall call 'No ball'.

6.2 Ball Tampering

No player may alter the condition of the ball using artificial substances, rubbing against rough surfaces, or picking at the seam. Any infringement results in a **5-penalty-run award** to the opposing team and immediate replacement of the ball.

***Note on Penalty Runs:** Penalty runs (typically 5 runs) are awarded to the batting team if the fielding side causes unfair damage to the pitch, tampers with the ball, or if the ball strikes a helmet placed on the ground by the fielding side.*